SAMPLE

The Guardian's Shadow: Pocong

The Shrouded Ghost — Death, Burial, and the Corpse That Cannot Rest

Aiden Nightfall

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The Guardian's Shadow

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Introduction

It is near midnight, and the graveyard is not as empty as you were told. Between the grave-posts something white moves — not walking, not drifting, but hopping, both feet leaving the ground together, the way a thing moves when its legs are bound. It is wrapped head to foot in white cloth, tied at the head, the chest, the hips, the knees, the feet. Its face is covered. Or its eyes are not. And it is coming toward you, one bound jump at a time, because it cannot come any other way.

If you grew up in Indonesia, you already know what this is. In Malaysia, you know it by another name — hantu bungkus, the wrapped-up ghost. The pocong.

The pocong is arguably the most iconic ghost of the modern Malay- Indonesian world. It is also the only ghost in this series that is, in the most literal sense, a burial gone wrong. Every Muslim in the archipelago is buried in the same white shroud, tied with the same knots. The tradition that produces the pocong is not some marginal sorcery practised by a few pawangs in the forest, like the polong of Volume 6 or the bajang of Volume 8. It is the universal rite. Everyone attends the washing. Everyone carries the bier. Everyone has seen the knots tied — and everyone knows, at some level, that the last thing done to the people we bury is to wrap them, bind them, and lower them into the ground still wearing the cloth that is now their only garment.

The pocong is what happens when that rite fails. When the knots are never loosed. When the body is bound and buried and left — and something in the dead person, or something about the death, refuses the arrangement.

This book follows the pocong from the rite that makes it to the films that made it famous. Over the next ten chapters, you will learn exactly how a corpse is shrouded and knotted in the Malay-Indonesian burial rite, what the tradition says the knots do to the soul, why the corpse is believed to sit up in its shroud at the graveside, what powers the pocong is believed to possess, how Malay and Indonesian societies have lived with — and managed — this belief, how to protect yourself, how the pocong conquered modern media, what moral lessons the tradition carries, what science and psychology say about why people see hopping shrouds in graveyards, and what the pocong still means in a world of mortuaries and memorial parks.

One warning before the first chapter. The pocong is the ghost nearest to the reader of this series, because its birthplace is not the forest, or the river, or the abandoned house. It is the funeral you yourself will one day be given. The shroud is waiting for all of us. The only question the folklore asks is whether

anyone will untie the knots.

Chapter 1: What Is Pocong? The Shrouded

Ghost of Malay-Indonesian Folklore Explained

A pocong is the spirit of a dead person trapped inside its own burial shroud. That is the whole definition, and every detail of the ghost follows from it. The shroud — kain kapan in Malay, kain kafan in Indonesian — is the plain white cotton cloth in which Muslim corpses are wrapped for burial. The living person becomes a corpse; the corpse is washed, wrapped, knotted, and buried; and if the rite is not completed correctly, the person does not rest. They remain in the shroud, standing, hopping, or rolling through the night, neither buried nor gone, held in the world by the very cloth that was meant to send them out of it.

The tradition is shared across Indonesia and Malaysia, and the ghost wears different names in different places. In Malaysia it is often called hantu bungkus — literally the "wrapped ghost," or "bundle ghost." Indonesian tradition also knows it as hantu guling, the rolling ghost, after the way a bound body moves when it cannot walk. The name pocong itself has become the standard term, so dominant in modern culture that it has nearly driven the older names out of use.

The pocong's appearance is fixed by its origin: it looks like exactly what it is — a corpse in a shroud. A white, head-to-foot wrapping of cloth, tied at intervals with knotted strips torn from the shroud's own hem. The head is covered; in most tellings a single knot above the head keeps the face enclosed, though many stories insist that the face — or just the eyes — is somehow visible. Some pocongs are darkly stained. Some are clean. Some appear greenish in the lantern light, and Indonesian folklore has its own taxonomy of colours and faces that local tellings attach to the shroud.

What never varies is the binding: this is a body that has been tied, and a body that has been tied cannot walk. So it hops. Both feet together, a clumsy, jolting, terrible progress — or it leans and rolls, guling, tumbling like a log. The locomotion is the ghost's signature. The hopping pocong is one of the most recognised silhouettes in all of Southeast Asian horror.

The pocong belongs to the graveyard. It rises from its own grave, or from the grave whose knots were never untied, and it is seen at night — near cemeteries, on the paths that pass them, and in the places where funerals go wrong. Unlike the pontianak, who haunts banana groves and crossroads, or the langsuir, who cries from the forest edge, the pocong appears exactly where the community buries its dead. Encounters cluster around new graves. The tradition knows why, and Chapter 3 will explain it in full: the pocong is born at the burial.

A short clearing of the ground, because the pocong is often confused with its cousins from other traditions. The pocong is not a vampire: it drinks nothing and turns no one; its nearest analogue in the Western imagination is not Dracula but the revenant — the restless dead who walk because their affairs are unsettled. It is not a zombie: nothing controls a pocong, it is not anyone's servant, and it does not multiply. It is not a ghost in the Western sense of a haunting remnant — the tradition is more literal than that: the pocong is the whole person, corpse and soul together, wrapped, and prevented from proceeding. And it is not a demon, which matters for the series' catalogue: the pocong has no master, no maker, and no malice. Of the twelve beings that came before it in this series, the pocong is the only one that wants nothing but its own paperwork completed.

The names tell the tradition's own history. Pocong — the modern standard term on both sides of the strait — is the name the culture settled on as the belief went mass-market, and its very blankness helped: a word with no story attached, perfect for a screen ghost. Hantu bungkus, the Malaysian "wrapped ghost," is the folk register's name — descriptive, homely, almost domestic, the name you would use at a funeral. And hantu guling, the "rolling ghost," is the name of the behaviour rather than the costume, which is the oldest way the tradition had of naming its beings (compare the langsuir's own name from the owl). Three names, three strata: what it is (wrapped), what it does (rolls), and what the cinema called it (pocong).

Here is the fact that sets the pocong apart from every other being in this series. The langsuir is born of a specific tragedy — death in childbirth. The polong is deliberately created by a sorcerer. The bajang is made from a stillborn child. But everyone dies. The shroud waits for every reader of this book, and the burial rite that produces the pocong is the same rite that will be performed for you, in a form essentially unchanged for centuries, by a community that will wash you, wrap you, knot you, and answer for you at the graveside. The pocong is not a marginal demon. It is the failure mode of the one ceremony no one escapes. That is why it frightens like no other ghost — and why, as we will see, it is also the gentlest figure in the catalogue, a ghost that is not trying to hurt the living at all, but only asking them for one small, specific, merciful thing.

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